

# PHENOMENOLOGY OF PERCEPTION



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*“In the same way, the sensible does not merely have a motor and vital signification, but is rather nothing other than a certain manner of being in the world that is proposed to us from a point in space, that our body takes up and adopt if it is capable, and sensation is, literally, a communion” (219)*

Colour provokes a certain way of being, it advises an action or an attitude. Red and yellow advise a stretching out and away, blue and green a drawing in and upon of. The amateur colour-theorist in me wants to generalize and rationalize; warm colours relax the muscles, heat opens up, it expands...cool colours signal a retreat within, a fetal repositioning, a climb back up into the womb to escape the harshness.

The point of interest here is the apparent predisposition to qualities that unconsciously advise action. That the studies show repetition among several subjects reveals an innate knowledge here, perhaps unvocalized and unrationalized, but indeed a tendency to react in an organically/biologically prescribed manner? Innate insofar as we forego a tabula rasa conception of mind and body, which would ask instead for a variety in test material amongst the subjects.

The ramifications for art theory are apparent, but I want to investigate environment. When I go to the park to practice my exercises the change in environment, perhaps by only by a few meters from sidewalk, advises an entirely new relation to my surroundings. Grading is more intense, the slight rise that occurs in front of me is distinguished; I call it a ‘glen’. The glen overlooks a section of the park, it offers me a vantage point. I am drawn to the glen like the ancient wise man of the tribe choosing the appropriate place to camp for the night – it is a strategic locale. When I am exercising I am vulnerable, there are moments when I am bent over, I cannot maintain awareness of my surroundings. The glen protects me – no one can sneak up on me, to pounce on me all unawares.

I am barefoot in the park, and I look to place mostly my feet in good areas - where the sun will touch, where grass grows, where there is less traffic; I want to avoid traffic, overpopulation, people in shoes and jackets and reeking of civilization. In this way I am not separate from my environ, I draw from it, it advises my actions. When I enter the park I am no longer the same sort of thing I was on the street; I become the hunter, I seek out favourable land.

*“If qualities radiate a certain mode of existence around themselves, if they have a power to enchant, or if they have what we called earlier a sacramental value, this is because the sensing object does not posit them as objects, but sympathizes with them, makes them its own, and finds in them his momentary law” (221)*